

Chapter 103-4

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When Liang Shi arrived at the kitchen, her heartbeat still hadn't returned to normal speed.

The two words "a hug" spoken by Xu Qingzhu were enough to make one's heart race.

And Xu Qingzhu had even kissed her on the cheek.

Xu Qingzhu said she needed a hug.

The formal word for "embrace" wasn't enough to share the joy she had received, but the cutesy "hug" could.¹

That tender, gentle voice made one's heart beat rapidly and non-stop, as if the whole person was about to explode on the spot.

In her mind, it was like New Year's, with firecrackers popping and crackling, yet it didn't feel noisy at all.

Only joy.

A comfortable joy.

Liang Shi leaned against the cold wall of the kitchen, resting her head against it too.

But the coldness didn't cool down her body. She pressed her hand over her heart, wanting it to quickly return to a normal heartbeat.

It was difficult.

Xu Qingzhu's voice echoed in her ears again and again.

Liang Shi couldn't calm down enough to cook.

So she chose to eat out, and sent a phone message to Xu Qingzhu: 【Get up.】

Two words that looked particularly cold, without a hint of warmth.

So Liang Shi added another line: 【Let's go eat downstairs.】

Without a sentence-final particle, this sentence would also seem cold, but adding a "ba" instantly changed the attitude.²

Liang Shi stared at the screen, and a few seconds later sent another message: 【Xu Qingzhu, let's go.】

This "ya" particle added a few more degrees of warmth, as if showing vulnerability.²

However, above the message, what was originally the contact name "Xu Qingzhu" had suddenly changed to "The other party is typing."

This typing lasted five seconds. Liang Shi stared intently at the screen, waiting for her reply.

But suddenly, Xu Qingzhu's voice came from the master bedroom. "Teacher Liang, don't you think this apartment is especially big?"

Her voice was lazy, not loud, with a casual air.

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a white spaghetti-strap nightgown, her shoulders exposed. Her slender, fair forearm rested on the door frame, her fine, soft long hair cascading down.

She was barefoot, with everything below her knees uncovered.

Xu Qingzhu leaned casually against the door, and her gaze happened to meet Liang Shi's as she walked out of the kitchen.

Xu Qingzhu had a smile at the corner of her lips, the corners of her eyes tilted upward. "It's only a few steps away. Do you need to use your phone?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's gaze darted everywhere—she just didn't dare look at her.

Clearly she was the one who should be considered at a disadvantage, yet she was so at ease that it made Liang Shi feel awkward.

"Don't you want to talk to me anymore?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: ".....No."

Liang Shi said it without much conviction. She felt she urgently needed to go outside for some fresh air, to change the environment.

If she stayed in this space any longer, she would probably suffocate to death or die from a racing heart.

"Jiejie."³ Xu Qingzhu's voice was light, already returned to normal, yet it still made Liang Shi's heart skip a beat.

It was as if she had heard this voice somewhere before.

The same way of calling, even the pause in the middle was the same—always liking to break in the middle.

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu in surprise, but her eyes immediately caught sight of Xu Qingzhu's bare feet.

The fair feet formed a stark contrast with the natural wood-colored floor.

It was a very beautiful scene, even quite artistic.

It could be appreciated as a painting.

But for Liang Shi, her first reaction was—the floor didn't have heating yet, she would catch a cold.

In spring and autumn, one shouldn't walk barefoot on the floor.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and repeated, "Jiejie, can you give me something to eat? I want to eat at home."

Liang Shi: "....."

She pressed her lips together. "Go back to the room and wait."

Xu Qingzhu: "Okay."

Yet she still stood there without moving.

Liang Shi didn't move either. After a few seconds of eye contact, it was ultimately Liang Shi who gave in. She walked back to the master bedroom, passed right by Xu Qingzhu, got her slippers and placed them by her feet, then half-crouched down and said in a low voice, "Lift your foot."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She lowered her eyes, swallowed, and lifted her foot slightly.

Liang Shi patiently helped her put on the slippers, just like she usually did with Ling Dang.

No, even more attentively than that.

She didn't treat her any differently just because she was an adult.

But when Liang Shi stood up, Xu Qingzhu suddenly grabbed her wrist. Her fingertip rubbed against her pulse point and felt her racing heartbeat.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly laughed softly. "Teacher Liang, your heart beats this fast just from helping me put on shoes?"

Liang Shi: ".....No."

Her denial had no persuasive power in the face of her accelerating heartbeat.

But she wanted to leave, to escape from this environment that left her at a loss. Yet she was held back by Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi asked in a low voice, "Are you going to eat or not?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled. "Yes."

Liang Shi: "Then let go."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly reached out with her free arm, pulled her down directly, then stood on tiptoe and kissed her on the lips.

It wasn't a very lingering kiss, nor were there any excessive movements.

It ended quickly.

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the door and smiled, with a hint of mischief. "Teacher Liang, is your heart beating fast now?"

1. In Chinese, "擁抱" (yōngbào) is the formal word for "embrace/hug," while "抱抱" (bàobao) is a cutesy, reduplicated form that sounds more affectionate and childlike, similar to saying "huggy" or "gimme a hug" in English. ↵
2. Chinese sentence-final particles like "吧" (ba) and "呀" (ya) add nuance to sentences. "吧" softens a statement into a suggestion, while "呀" adds a friendly, gentle, or slightly pleading tone. Without these particles, sentences can sound blunt or cold. ↵ ↵²
3. "Jiejie" (姐姐) means "older sister" in Chinese. It's used here as an intimate term of address, which is particularly significant given the context of their relationship. Xu Qingzhu calling Liang Shi "jiejie" carries romantic and affectionate undertones. ↵